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Business Intelligence Analyst Skills: Definition and Examples

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Business intelligence refers to data as it relates to business operations and performance. Business intelligence analysts are the professionals who interpret this data and generate insights that decision-makers can use to guide their leadership. The job of business intelligence analysis requires various hard and soft skills to find data, understand it and transform it into usable knowledge. In this article, we discuss what business intelligence analysts do, explore some examples of common skills for business intelligence analysts, explain how you can improve your [business intelligence analyst](#)  skills and provide tips on how to highlight these skills.

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What are the skills of a business intelligence analyst?

[Business intelligence](#) [↗](#) analysts review and interpret data to help managers, executives and other business leaders make decisions that improve the operations of their business. The data they analyze may be internal, such as sales and marketing data, or external, such as surveys and market research. Business intelligence analysts can use this data to identify factors such as industry trends and company-specific areas of improvement to provide insights on how to resolve problems or increase efficiency.

In order to handle these duties, business intelligence analysts should have a variety of skills. They need a combination of hard and soft skills to operate the technology needed for the job and to convey the complex data they analyze to clients and coworkers. If you're interested in this role, it's important to develop the necessary skills.

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Examples of business intelligence analyst skills

Here are some examples of business [intelligence analyst](#) [↗](#) skills:

Data analysis

A business intelligence analyst primarily interprets large amounts of data, so data analysis is an essential skill in this profession. They must be able to examine various

data sources, realize connections between them and draw accurate conclusions based on what they see.

Data tools

Business intelligence analysts use a variety of tools to access, analyze and visualize data. They may need knowledge of Structured Query Language, or SQL, a tool for allowing analysts to query databases and pull the data they need. Other tools that business intelligence analysts might use are Tableau and Power BI, software with which they can pull from data sources and produce visualizations such as graphs.

Programming

Programming can be a useful skill to a business intelligence analyst because it allows them to create scripts, or sequences of instructions, that can automate data-related functions, such as locating and modifying specific data. This can help them manage their tasks and expedite their workflow. Programs such as SQL and Python, an advanced programming language, are common tools in business intelligence.

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Domain knowledge

Domain knowledge refers to knowledge about the industry in which you work. Having domain knowledge can help business analysts understand the data they examine, make more accurate interpretations and devise applicable solutions. For example, an analyst working in the insurance industry should know the factors that influence sales fluctuations in order to make actionable suggestions for improvement.

Business acumen

Having business acumen means that you can understand and handle business circumstances to generate a positive outcome. Because business intelligence analysts must offer solutions based on the data they interpret, their business acumen can help devise useful solutions and metrics for measuring improvements.

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Communication

A primary function of business intelligence analysts is translating data into information that others can understand. They must be able to describe data, explain their interpretation of it and outline actions the company can take based on the data interpretation. This process can involve conveying complex technical concepts to people who are unfamiliar with the terminology and systems involved.

Problem-solving

Business intelligence analysts interpret data in order to identify problem areas and then present solutions to those problems based on the data. The job involves devising actionable suggestions to improve operations and influence better decision-making.

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Critical thinking

Critical thinking allows business intelligence analysts to process information in order to recognize the connections, implications or potential applications of the data they analyze. For example, presented with information on cycle times, sales and client satisfaction, the analyst could make a conclusion about their interconnectivity.

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Attention to detail

When mining data, skilled business intelligence analysts might notice that even minute pieces of data can translate into usable insights for the company. Pinpointing such data amid substantial amounts of other information can improve the accuracy of intelligence reports and the quality of insights.

Organization

Business intelligence analysts often work on several reports at a time, requiring that they analyze distinct groups of data for separate purposes simultaneously. Thus, it's important that they keep their tasks organized so that there's no crossover data between tasks and they maintain a smooth workflow to complete their assignments on time.

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How to improve business intelligence analyst skills

Improving your business intelligence analyst skills can help you stand out against other candidates and improve your candidacy for the jobs you want. Here are some ways you can improve your business intelligence analyst skills:

1. Pursue further education

Pursuing a degree in a discipline related to business intelligence analysis can equip you with new skills or strengthen existing ones. For example, disciplines like computer science can provide you with a deeper understanding of the systems and tools that business intelligence analysts work with, while courses in statistics can train you to extrapolate meaning from numerical data.

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2. Take training courses

Many organizations offer in-person or online training courses on business intelligence concepts and tools. Some courses may focus on how to use specific advanced tools such as data warehouses or large repositories of data from several sources. Others may provide overviews of a large number of reporting tools and dashboards, which are management tools that can track data points such as metrics and key performance indicators.

3. Get certified

Professional certification courses can help you improve your analysis skills or adeptness with business analysis tools. Certificates are available at various levels of experience, including:

- **Tableau Desktop Certified Associate:** This certification shows that the holder has a strong understanding of the functions of Tableau Desktop, a common business intelligence tool. You should have at least five months of experience with Tableau before applying for certification, which requires earning a minimum of 75 % on a 36-question exam.
- **IBM Certified Designer—IBM Cognos Analytics Author V11:** This certifies that you have shown skills related to creating, enhancing and customizing advanced reports. Applicants should have experience with creating intermediate-level and complex reports as well as dashboards. You must earn a minimum of 70% on a 60-question exam to earn this certification.
- **Certified Business Intelligence Professional (CBIP):** The CBIP program, which is for senior-level analysts, certifies that you're knowledgeable of current technologies, practices, trends and solutions in business intelligence. Certification requires passing three exams, and there are two levels of certification depending on how well you perform on the exams. The practitioner certification requires a score of at least 50% on each exam, while master certification requires at least 70%.

Business intelligence analyst skills in the workplace

You can apply your business intelligence analyst skills in the workplace in the following ways:

- **Ask questions.** To determine solutions, you often need input from the people whose problems you're hoping to solve. Asking questions about stakeholders' goals, what they want to know and why they want to know it can help you interpret their needs and how to approach the data.

- **Spread your data and solutions.** As a business intelligence analyst, working with many departments, you may mine data for one department that could also be useful for another, or a solution adopted by one team could equally benefit others. Spreading these insights can not only improve the organization but also improve your own efficiency.
- **Approach the data with fresh eyes.** Data you've already analyzed can generate new insights depending on how and where it's applied. Try to focus on the specific situation at hand to see data with fresh eyes and make novel recommendations.
- **Question yourself.** Before presenting your insights and solutions, ask yourself whether you might be wrong. Re-examine the data and reassess your conclusions in order to provide the best analysis.

Do you need help with your resume?

Yes

No

How to highlight business intelligence analyst skills

Here are some ways you can highlight your business intelligence analyst skills on your resume, on your cover letter and in a job interview:

Business intelligence skills on your resume

You can structure your resume to mention key business intelligence analysis skills in several areas. Try including a resume objective in which you use keywords from the job description and relevant skills that you possess. For example, in the objective, you could describe yourself as a "meticulous, results-oriented analyst with proven experience as a critical thinker and [problem solver](#) [🔗](#)," which covers four key analyst skills. Later, in the skills section, you can explain your qualifications in greater detail.

If you have relevant job experience, try to relate your key achievements to relevant business intelligence skills. Consider thinking of specific solutions you've offered based on your data analysis, and mention the result.

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Business intelligence skills on your cover letter

Your cover letter is where you can expound on details mentioned in your resume. Try to provide a concise narrative of your experience in analyzing business data, noting specific successes your analyses have produced. For instance, perhaps you once saw a connection between data points that weren't immediately apparent, and that led you to produce an insight that helped a company increase its profits. That anecdote may be worth including in the body or even the introduction of your cover letter.

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Business intelligence skills in your interview

Try to prepare for your interview by drafting potential responses that involve mentioning your experience with business intelligence tools and your savvy with analysis. For instance, in response to a question about your biggest weakness, you might note that you often fixate for long periods on small data points to mine as much meaning as you can from them. With this response, you can imply that your weakness is actually the strength of a detail-oriented mind, which is a key skill for business intelligence analysts.

Please note that none of the companies mentioned in this article are affiliated with Indeed.



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